

Chapter 96-1

Liang Shi had actually forgotten about this.

However, she had a habit of making her bed every day when she got up, and she always kept the room tidy and clean. After the three little girls came inside, they looked around everywhere—especially Sheng Yu and Ling Dang.

Actually, Ling Dang wasn't that wild, but being led by Sheng Yu, the "mischief genes" in her body awakened. The two of them went into the kitchen, then went to look at the bathroom, then peeked into the master bedroom, and then went to look at the second bedroom.

None of the doors were locked—they opened with just a push.

It was already too late.

Sheng Yu was a bit taller than Ling Dang, so opening doors was no big deal for her. After opening the second bedroom, she exclaimed in surprise, "Wow, it's sky blue!"

Ling Dang also leaned in. "Dummy, it's aqua blue."

Rainbow stood behind them. "It's Klein blue."

Liang Shi: "....."

Her head suddenly started to ache.

Sheng Yu immediately called out, "Sister, what kind of blue do you think that is?"

Xu Qingzhu responded, "Whatever blue you think it is, that's what it is."

The three children: "?"

Sheng Yu huffed softly. "You're just brushing me off."

"Then what do you want me to say?" Xu Qingzhu beckoned to them. "It's just one shade of blue, and you've divided it into so many types. Aren't you tired?"

Sheng Yu: "....."

Meanwhile, Su Yao was also essentially taking a tour. She stood at the doorway and glanced inside, then said softly, "The house is very clean."

Liang Shi smiled awkwardly. "It's alright. No one has slept on these sheets for a long time. We usually don't open this door."

Xu Qingzhu was sitting on the sofa coaxing the children, but she had her ears perked up, eavesdropping on Liang Shi's conversation.

After hearing those words, she couldn't help but glance at Liang Shi. Liang Shi shrugged at her—Can't help it, I didn't mean to lie either.

Sheng Yu, who was sitting on the sofa, was about to have a proper discussion about the blue color when Xu Qingzhu took out some snacks from the coffee table drawer. "Here, have some. If you want to watch TV, you can watch together."

Sheng Yu: "....."

"Aunt-Mother, I want to watch *Erta the Rabbit*¹." Ling Dang said.

Sheng Yu frowned. "No way. Let's watch *Hamster Eats Grain*."

Rainbow had originally been sitting at the edge to stay out of things, but Xu Qingzhu pulled her to sit in the middle. "You're in charge of being their referee. As long as they don't start fighting, it's fine."

After saying that, she paused and added, "Even if they do fight, see which one of them is stronger, then tell me."

Sheng Yu & Ling Dang: "?"

Xu Qingzhu's method of handling children was simple and brutal.

Poor Rainbow was given this heavy responsibility, sitting in the middle being stared at by two pairs of eyes.

Rainbow felt immense pressure. Holding the TV remote in her hand, she tentatively asked, "How about we watch *Explore Nature*?"

Sheng Yu & Ling Dang: "....."

Sheng Yu sighed. "Liang Wenxuan, do you want to watch *Hamster Eats Grain* or *Explore Nature*?"

"Watch *Terra the Rabbit*." Ling Dang absolutely would not yield on matters like this. She even tried to negotiate with Sheng Yu. "How about we watch two episodes of *Terra the Rabbit* and then watch *Hamster Eats Grain*?"

Sheng Yu thought for a moment. "That works too."

Rainbow sat between them and asked helplessly, "What about *Explore Nature*?"

"Huh?" Sheng Yu shook her head. "I can't understand it. Liang Wenxuan, can you understand it?"

Ling Dang also shook her head. "I can't understand it either."

When it came to refusing additional educational content, the two joined forces and defeated Rainbow.

As it turned out, Xu Qingzhu's rough parenting method had some merit to it.

Five minutes later, the house was relatively much quieter than before.

They shared snacks while watching cartoons, watching with great enjoyment.

Apart from the sound of snack bags being opened, there was only the TV sound. And they were quite considerate—they didn't turn the TV volume up too loud.

Looking at the three of them sitting in a row, Liang Shi couldn't help but give Xu Qingzhu a thumbs up. Then she whispered to her, "I was almost driven crazy on the way here. Sheng Yu is so energetic, and Ling Dang was screaming and arguing with her."

Xu Qingzhu crossed her arms and glanced over, smiling somewhat gleefully. "Poor Rainbow."

"Indeed." Liang Shi agreed.

Su Yao had already walked to the kitchen, wanting to help with something but not knowing where to start. She saw some garlic on the counter and stood there peeling it.

Liang Shi entered the kitchen and saw that she had already secretly started working. She immediately tried to push her out of the kitchen. "Mom, go watch TV with the children. Leave the kitchen to us."

"No need." Su Yao said. "I can help you out."

How could Liang Shi have the nerve to let Su Yao help? She was pushing and nudging, trying to get her to leave the kitchen, when Xu Qingzhu walked in wearing casual clothes. Seeing the two of them pushing back and forth, she said to Liang Shi, "Is the kitchen yours alone?"

Liang Shi: "?"

"Let's do it together." Xu Qingzhu glanced at Su Yao, took an apron down from the wall, and handed it over. "Be careful not to get your clothes dirty."

Su Yao immediately smiled. "Okay."

When Liang Shi used to look up information online, she always felt that people who deserved the title of "genius" were all cold and aloof types.

Like Zhao Xuning or Gu Yixue.

So in her stereotypical impression, Su Yao should also be a cold and aloof person.

For instance, when she first met Su Yao, she was wearing sunglasses and a long trench coat, and even her voice carried a cold edge.

But now, Su Yao was cautious and careful in front of Xu Qingzhu, walking on eggshells, wanting to get closer but afraid of getting too close—completely different from before.

Liang Shi thought about letting the mother and daughter cultivate their relationship.

Blood is thicker than water, and both of them wanted to understand each other.

Liang Shi could provide them with the opportunity.

¹ **Terra the Rabbit (兔子不哭):** The literal translation is "Rabbit Don't Cry" - this appears to be a fictional children's cartoon show in the story.

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Xu Qingzhu asked from the side, "So what are you planning to make for dinner?"

Liang Shi said, "Rice and stir-fried dishes, plus a soup."

"That's too much trouble." Xu Qingzhu looked at what she had bought. "How about we make dumplings?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Making dumplings seemed like even more trouble, actually.

But since Xu Qingzhu had suggested it, and Liang Shi knew how to make them, she could naturally oblige. When Xu Qingzhu proposed that she would knead the dough while Su Yao would be in charge of washing the vegetables, Liang Shi suddenly understood why Xu Qingzhu had suggested making dumplings.

Everyone would have something to do, so Su Yao wouldn't be left standing idle in the kitchen.

Liang Shi knew how to prepare dumpling filling, and she knew many different kinds.

Since Xu Qingzhu had mentioned it late, she prepared one vegetarian filling and one meat filling.

Mincing meat was a skilled task. Liang Shi's wrists were getting a bit sore from all the chopping. The "thud thud thud thud" sounds echoed in the kitchen, attracting the attention of the children watching TV in the living room. Sheng Yu ran over and hung on the door. "What are you doing?"

"Mincing meat." Liang Shi answered.

"What are we eating tonight?" Sheng Yu asked again.

Liang Shi said, "Dumplings."

Sheng Yu let out an "oh" and ran off to the living room to share the intel with Ling Dang and Rainbow.

Liang Shi had assumed that Xu Qingzhu confidently proposed kneading the dough because she knew how to do it.

But when she finished preparing the filling, the dough under Xu Qingzhu's hands had turned into a sticky mess. She was still adding more flour, even though there was already more than enough flour in the bowl.....

Su Yao watched from the side but didn't say anything.

The atmosphere was actually quite nice.

After all, even though Xu Qingzhu's hands were making a complete mess, her face maintained its confidence throughout.

Liang Shi couldn't help but speak up. "Let me do it."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

She didn't try to tough it out either. She shook off the dough from her hands, pushed the bowl over, and went to wash her hands.

The dough in Liang Shi's hands seemed to come alive, blending together following the direction of her hands, gradually forming into a proper dough ball.

Su Yao suddenly said, "Ah Shi, your cooking skills are quite good."

"It's alright." Liang Shi said. "At least I won't starve to death."

Su Yao smiled gently and praised, "Then our Zhuzi is lucky."

"What do you mean." Xu Qingzhu said quietly. "She's the lucky one."

Liang Shi chimed in, "Yes, marrying Zhuzi is my good fortune."

Xu Qingzhu froze and looked at Liang Shi, only to see Liang Shi with her head down, focused on kneading the dough. What she had just said seemed like it might have been her imagination.

But she had clearly said it.

Her hair was tied loosely, and by now several strands had come loose, hanging down and almost falling into the dough bowl.

Xu Qingzhu immediately brushed them back up for her. Standing behind her, she slid the hair tie off, then retied it a bit tighter. When she did the final tug, she pulled a bit too hard and it stung Liang Shi. "Teacher Xu, you pulled out my hair."

Xu Qingzhu looked sheepish and held out her hand in front of Liang Shi—there was indeed a strand of hair in her palm. "Sorry."

Liang Shi: "....."

Afraid it would fall into the food, Xu Qingzhu quickly threw the hair into the trash.

But Liang Shi said, "I've tied your hair so many times and never pulled any out. Are you trying to make me go bald?"

Xu Qingzhu cleared her throat lightly, feeling a bit guilty. "Sorry."

Standing in the kitchen, Su Yao felt like there was a barrier between herself and the two of them—she simply couldn't fit in.

The two had many small interactions, all formed through their daily accumulation of understanding. They could understand what the other wanted with just a glance.

Back when Su Yao and Sheng Qinglin were dating, it was only after living together for two years that they had developed this kind of tacit understanding.

She and Sheng Qinglin were already considered a match made in heaven in others' eyes.

Because she had experienced such love herself, she could tell at a glance whether it was an act or real.

Just by looking at how those two gazed at each other, Su Yao could tell—this was definitely not an act.

Although she had been fed a mouthful of dog food¹ and couldn't fit into their world, Su Yao was still happy watching them.

Being able to see her daughter happy and content was more important and fulfilling than anything else.

Back then, she had heard from Su Zhe that the person Zhuzi married wasn't good—that there were problems with her character. As for the specifics, Su Zhe didn't tell her much, only told her not to worry and that he would keep an eye on things.

But how could a mother not worry?

Although she had met Liang Shi before and had seen how the two of them interacted, feeling that Liang Shi seemed like a pretty good person who was genuinely good to Zhuzi, she was still afraid it might all be an act.

Su Yao had worried about this for a long time, but now all her worries had vanished like smoke.

Actions can deceive, but eyes cannot.

Liang Shi's sleeve was about to fall down. Xu Qingzhu rolled it up for her, and then noticed a bite mark on her arm. She asked who had bitten her.

Footnotes:

¹ **Dog food (狗粮):** Chinese internet slang referring to public displays of affection between couples. When someone witnesses a couple being lovey-dovey, they say they've been "fed dog food," similar to the English expression of being a "third wheel" but specifically referring to witnessing PDA.

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Liang Shi said helplessly, "Who else could it be?"

"Sheng Yu?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded. "Yeah. She even has a little tiger tooth—did you notice?"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu was about to go settle accounts with Sheng Yu, but Liang Shi stopped her, saying she had been bitten because she lost a bet to Sheng Yu.

After Sheng Yu bit her, she even felt embarrassed about it and rubbed the spot for her for a long time.

The bite mark would fade in another two hours—it didn't hurt at all.

Xu Qingzhu still went to the living room anyway. She sat down next to Sheng Yu and directly snatched the snacks from her hands.

Sheng Yu looked at her innocently, blinking. "What? Is it time to eat?"

"Time to eat people." Xu Qingzhu asked her. "Why do you like biting people?"

Sheng Yu: "....."

She huffed coldly. "Sister Liang has no martial ethics¹—she actually tattled!"

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"She lost a bet to me." Sheng Yu tattled back. "A bet is a bet. If I had lost, she would have bitten me too."

Xu Qingzhu asked her, "What did you two bet on?"

Sheng Yu pressed her lips together and stayed silent.

Ling Dang suddenly came over and raised her hand. "I know!"

Sheng Yu's eyes widened. She lunged forward to cover Ling Dang's mouth and threatened, "Liang Wenxuan, don't you dare say it!"

When it was almost time to eat, Xu Qingzhu took everyone to wash their hands. Taking advantage of the moment, she quietly asked Ling Dang, "What did they bet on?"

Ling Dang leaned close to her ear and said, "They bet on how many seeds were in a bag of sunflower seeds."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

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Wrapping dumplings was quite troublesome, but Liang Shi's hands were fast, and Su Yao also knew a bit. Only Xu Qingzhu was a beginner.

Yet Xu Qingzhu was the calmest of them all. Although the dumplings she wrapped could only be pinched shut at the top with no shape whatsoever, the confident expression on her face made people feel like the dumplings she made were the most beautiful dumplings in the whole world.

By the time they sat down to eat, it was already 8:30 PM.

The three children happened to not be hungry either. They had eaten ice cream cones after school, and then had snacks when they came back in the evening. Sitting on the sofa huddled together watching TV with great enjoyment, not a single one of them said they were hungry.

Liang Shi still brought the three of them to eat.

Rainbow didn't need anyone to look after her—she even took the initiative to help get the tableware. The other two were already sitting at the table discussing how many dumplings they were going to eat.

Sheng Yu said she wasn't hungry, so she would only eat three.

Ling Dang said she wasn't hungry either, but she would eat one more than Sheng Yu.

Within two minutes, their competitive spirits had escalated to the point where each of them was going to eat ten dumplings.

Then Sheng Yu proudly asked Xu Qingzhu, "Sister, do you think it's good if I eat ten dumplings?"

Xu Qingzhu's voice was cool and her face expressionless. "You'll burst."

Sheng Yu: "....."

Ling Dang happily ate her meal.

Su Yao had already given Su Zhe a heads-up earlier that she would be staying at Xu Qingzhu's place with Sheng Yu for the night.

During dinner, Rainbow made a video call to Zhou Li. Sheng Yu and Ling Dang acted cute through the video. "Hello, Auntie."

Liang Shi chatted with Zhou Li for a bit, and things finally settled down.

This was the first time this home had so many people in it—it felt alive with warmth.

Dusk had fallen on all sides, brilliant stars scattered across the firmament. Outside, lights glittered as streams of cars shuttled back and forth through the city. In this moment, the lights of countless homes seemed to converge at this small dining table.

Warm steam dispersed throughout the house, and the children's smiling faces were especially lovely.

Liang Shi had been busy for a long time and wasn't very hungry, but watching others eat gave her a sense of happiness.

While everyone was busy eating, Xu Qingzhu placed two dumplings in her bowl without saying a word, then lowered her head to continue eating.

The house didn't have many rooms, but the living room sofa was a fold-out—when unfolded, it became a bed.

Liang Shi's arrangement was to have Su Yao and Xu Qingzhu sleep in the master bedroom, the three children squeeze into the second bedroom, and she herself would sleep on the sofa.

The conditions were indeed a bit simple, but the three children had no objections.

Su Yao, however, said she could sleep on the sofa and let Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu share a room.

Liang Shi said helplessly, "You should stay with Zhuzi. You haven't seen each other in so many years—you can chat before bed."

Xu Qingzhu only hesitated for a moment before joining her in persuading Su Yao to sleep with her.

Fortunately, the bed in the second bedroom was big enough that having three children sleep in it wouldn't risk them falling off.

But even if they did fall off, it would be fine—Liang Shi had laid a soft, fluffy carpet beside the bed.

Footnotes:

¹ **No martial ethics (不講武德):** A popular Chinese internet meme originating from a video where an elderly martial arts master accused a younger opponent of having "no martial ethics" (meaning no sense of fair play or sportsmanship). It's now used humorously to accuse someone of being unfair or playing dirty, often in trivial situations.

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After dinner, the children went to wash up. Su Yao and Liang Shi cleaned up together, while Xu Qingzhu went to change the bed sheets in the room.

The children were old enough to wash up independently, especially with Rainbow watching over them. Liang Shi and the others were quite at ease.

Liang Shi and Su Yao stood together in the kitchen. Su Yao asked her what her current job was, whether she had any plans to have children, and things like that—purely asking from a mother's perspective. Liang Shi answered patiently.

Su Yao also asked how long she and Xu Qingzhu had dated and how long they had been married.

Liang Shi paused, feeling a bit embarrassed to say, so she could only make something up. "We dated for two months and have been married for almost half a year."

Liang Shi thought for a moment and added, "Mainly, from the moment I first saw her, I just knew it was her."

Su Yao was taken aback, then smiled after a moment. "How sweetly simple. When I first met Sheng Qinglin, I also felt that he would be the one for me for the rest of my life."

Whenever Sheng Qinglin was mentioned, Su Yao's eyes always had a light in them.

Liang Shi didn't dare linger on topics that would make her sad. While they were chatting, Xu Qingzhu stood at the doorway listening.

She heard that line—I just knew it was her.

Xu Qingzhu felt that it probably needed to be turned around.

Back then, it was after she met Liang Shi and learned that Liang Shi was that older sister from her childhood that she felt—then it would be her for this lifetime.

If it hadn't been for her back then, there wouldn't be the person she was today.

Xu Qingzhu gazed at her back, as gentle as always. The dim yellow light fell on her and Su Yao.

Every time she listened to Su Yao speak, she would slightly turn her body to listen carefully, afraid of missing a single word. Her gaze fell earnestly on Su Yao, and when she answered, her voice was soft and measured, with just the right amount of courtesy.

Xu Qingzhu was watching them in a daze when a loud cry suddenly rang out in the house—the kind that could blow the roof off—immediately pulling Xu Qingzhu's wandering thoughts back.

She glanced toward the bathroom, thinking that Sheng Yu and Ling Dang had gotten into another argument and cried. Not paying much attention, she was walking over unhurriedly when she heard Rainbow say, "Don't move, you're bleeding!"

Startled, Xu Qingzhu rushed to the bathroom. She saw Rainbow helping Sheng Yu stand up while Ling Dang stood there with a terrified expression, her hands trembling non-stop.

That cry just now had come from Sheng Yu. Her head had hit the floor—right on the non-slip tiles that had a small raised bump. Her nose was bleeding, and her forehead was scraped.

Ling Dang let out a frightened wail. "I'm sorry....."

The house immediately became chaotic.

Liang Shi and Su Yao arrived one after another. Su Yao immediately went to check Sheng Yu's injuries. She had Sheng Yu lower her head, then got some water to wash the blood from Sheng Yu's nose. Sheng Yu cried for a little while but quickly stopped.

Soon, the only crying echoing in the room was Ling Dang's.

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After Sheng Yu's nosebleed stopped, her forehead was also scraped—red and purple, looking quite alarming. She definitely needed to be taken to the hospital to have it treated.

Liang Shi immediately crouched down to comfort Ling Dang. "Don't cry for now....."

"Liang Wenxuan." Sheng Yu's nose was stuffed, so her voice sounded muffled. Having just cried, she was still hiccupping as she spoke, but she still called out, "Stop crying! I didn't even scold you!"

Ling Dang cried as she apologized. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean to."

Sheng Yu tilted her head up. "My head hurts, but..... your crying is making it hurt even more."

Ling Dang instantly stopped crying, though she was still hiccupping.

Liang Shi quickly changed her clothes to take Sheng Yu to the children's hospital to have her wound treated and see if she needed to get a scan done, since it involved her head after all.

Ling Dang said she wanted to go along too.

Only Su Yao and Rainbow were left at home.

Su Yao was worried too, but Xu Qingzhu said it was too cold at night and they were just going nearby for a check-up. They would be back soon, and she could call if anything came up.

Only then did Su Yao stay behind.

After getting in the car, both children's eyes were red from crying. Sheng Yu was doing a bit better than Ling Dang.

Ling Dang had already been crying for a day and a night. She had just started feeling a bit better, and now Sheng Yu had gotten hurt. She felt incredibly guilty and remorseful, apologizing to Sheng Yu non-stop in the car.

Sheng Yu covered her mouth. "You're so annoying, Liang Wenxuan."

Sheng Yu's voice was soft and milky, with an air of arrogance as she spoke. "I slipped and fell on my own. Why do you keep saying sorry? You just gave me a little push and I lost my balance. I'm not like that two-year-old boy. Hmph!"

Ling Dang was made to laugh by her expression.

Finally, she stopped crying.

Chapter 96-5

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The nearby pediatric hospital was just a five-minute drive away. It happened to be the same hospital that little boy had come to yesterday.

According to Sun Meirou, the other party was afraid there might be aftereffects or something, so they wanted the boy to stay for observation for five days. The expenses would naturally be covered by the Liang family.

At the time, Sun Meirou felt this was unreasonable, but Qiu Zimin didn't want Liang Xinran to be upset. Since it was just a small amount of money, she naturally accepted it.

The benefit of the house being close to the medical university was that there were many different types of hospitals nearby. This medical university-affiliated children's hospital was the best children's hospital in Haizhou City, and hospital beds were hard to come by.

That little boy was truly a waste of medical resources.

After all, how badly could you get hurt from being bumped by a small shopping cart?

Liang Shi wasn't in the mood to think about that right now.

There weren't many people at the hospital at this hour. Liang Shi carried Sheng Yu into the hospital while Xu Qingzhu went to register.

The two of them went upstairs to the department together. When registering, the staff reminded them to hurry if they were going—shift change was coming up soon, and there would be a 10-15 minute gap. So Liang Shi practically ran upstairs while carrying Sheng Yu. Even though she was an Alpha with good stamina, she was still out of breath from running upstairs while holding Sheng Yu.

But they made it just in time—the doctor was still in the office.

The doctor was in the middle of taking off her white coat. Liang Shi set Sheng Yu down on a chair. "Doctor, the child bumped her head. Could you please treat the wound....."

As she spoke, the other person put her half-removed white coat back on and turned around. Liang Shi's words suddenly got stuck.

Seeing that it was her, Shen Hui was also startled. However, she took out a mask from her pocket and put it on. Without speaking to Liang Shi, she walked directly over to Sheng Yu. She first smiled at Sheng Yu, her eyes curving in a particularly warm manner. "Little one, how did you get hurt?"

"I fell on the floor." Sheng Yu said. "I hit the floor."

Shen Hui first examined her wound, then took out disinfecting supplies from the cabinet. She pulled up a chair and sat in front of Sheng Yu, speaking gently. "Auntie is going to treat your wound now. If it hurts, you can grab onto Auntie's sleeve, okay? But don't cry—if you cry, you won't be pretty anymore."

Sheng Yu bit her lip. Fear flashed in her eyes, but she still answered bravely, "Okay."

Xu Qingzhu, who had come up after Liang Shi, stood at the doorway. She hadn't seen that it was Shen Hui. Seeing Sheng Yu sitting there obediently while the doctor treated her wound, she asked Liang Shi, "What did the doctor say? Is it serious?"

Liang Shi shook her head. "We don't know yet."

"It's not serious." Shen Hui's cool, clear voice sounded. "She just bumped it. It might swell tomorrow. I'll do some emergency treatment first. If you're worried something might be wrong, when you come back tomorrow to change the dressing, you can go to the neurology department for a CT scan to see if there's any bleeding in the brain. But it should be fine—bumps and scrapes are normal for children."

"It hurts....." Sheng Yu said quietly, on the verge of tears.

Ling Dang quickly walked over and held her hand. "I'm sorry....."

Sheng Yu huffed softly. "Liang Wenxuan, you're saying sorry again."

Ling Dang lowered her head guiltily.

"Did you knock her down?" When Shen Hui spoke with children, her voice was very gentle, just like a preschool teacher coaxing little ones.

Ling Dang nodded in admission, but Sheng Yu said, "I fell on my own."

"Then you're really brave." Shen Hui said. "Usually, children who get hurt like this would cry."

Sheng Yu answered proudly, "I'm not an ordinary child!"

"Really? Then you're amazing!" Shen Hui praised her while her hands moved steadily, finishing up the bandage.

By now, Xu Qingzhu had finally recognized her voice. She leaned close to Liang Shi's ear and whispered, "Is that Zhao Xuning's ex-girlfriend?"

Liang Shi nodded. "Yes."

Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue. "She's like a completely different person when she's working."

Before, Xu Qingzhu had seen her cold and aloof demeanor, had also seen her smile alluringly, and she had even greeted her in a friendly manner and apologized.

But when working, Shen Hui radiated a maternal glow. She was very gentle, and the children all liked chatting with her.

Liang Shi nodded in agreement with what she said, but still said with some confusion, "I feel like she really dislikes me. Why?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't understand either. She had just come in, so she could only guess. "Could it be because of Zhao Xuning?"

"It shouldn't be." Liang Shi said. "If she hated me by association¹, shouldn't she dislike you too? But she's very friendly to you."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She was silent for a moment, then leaned close to Liang Shi's ear and blew a breath of air. "Maybe it's because I'm pretty."

Liang Shi: "?"

"She said before that she likes beautiful women." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "....."

Was her appearance not good enough?

But the two of them only whispered for a moment. Shen Hui finished quickly and also treated Sheng Yu's nosebleed—patient and gentle throughout.

After finishing, she took off her mask and only then noticed there was another person in the room. Seeing who it was, she was momentarily stunned and asked in disbelief, "You two came together?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "What a coincidence. We meet again."

Shen Hui nodded. "What a coincidence."

Her face was full of fatigue. After working all day, she was very tired and had no intention of catching up.

She conveniently ignored Liang Shi standing beside her.

Indeed, Xu Qingzhu could also sense Shen Hui's hostility toward Liang Shi.

How baffling.

Just as Shen Hui was about to take off her white coat again to get off work, the door was pushed open. A woman ran in, gasping for breath. "Dr. Shen, please come quickly and take a look. My son has a fever."

Shen Hui's movements paused. She let out an imperceptible sigh, then resignedly buttoned up her white coat again. "Let's go."

She had just taken one step when the woman suddenly spotted Ling Dang standing to the side. She gnashed her teeth and cursed, "You dare show up here?! You little wretch²!"

The moment those words came out, Ling Dang's body shrank back. Tears fell from her eyes, but she didn't dare cry out loud.

The expressions of all the adults in the office changed simultaneously.

Footnotes:

¹ **Hated by association (恨屋及烏):** This is a reversal of the Chinese idiom "愛屋及烏" (ài wū jí wū), which literally means "love the house, love the crow on it"—meaning to love someone so much that you also love everything associated with them. Here, Liang Shi is using the opposite concept: hating someone so much that you hate everyone associated with them.

² **Little wretch (賤蹄子):** A vulgar insult literally meaning "cheap/lowly hoof," traditionally used to demean women and girls. It's an extremely offensive and degrading term, particularly shocking when directed at a child.